

Third Sunday After Pentecost

Dominica Tertia Post Pentecosten

TLM propers: the endangered sinner sought, strengthened, and welcomed into joy

Proper	TLM text / reference	Scriptural axis	Connection
Introit	<i>Respice in me, et miserere mei</i> (Ps. 24:16, 18)	Solitude, poverty, mercy	The worshipper enters neither self-sufficient nor hidden: affliction and sin are placed under God's merciful gaze.
Collect	<i>Protector in te sperantium, Deus</i>	Providence and pilgrimage	God's mercy supplies what is neither strong nor holy without him and orders temporal goods toward eternity.
Epistle	1 Pet. 5:6–11	Humility, trust, vigilance	Casting care on God and resisting the devil are one movement of humble, active faith.
Gradual	<i>Iacta cogitatum tuum in Domino</i> (Ps. 54:23, 17, 19)	Entrusted anxiety and deliverance	Before the Gospel, the congregation practices entrusting the anxiety that makes isolation and despair attractive.
Alleluia	<i>Deus iudex iustus, fortis et pateriens</i> (Ps. 7:12)	Justice, strength, patience	Divine patience opens the Gospel's mercy without denying judgment.
Gospel	Luke 15:1–10	Sheep, drachma, repentance, joy	Christ answers proud murmuring by revealing the search for sinners and heaven's joy at their repentance.
Offertory	<i>Sperent in te omnes</i> (Ps. 9:11–13)	Trust and the poor man's prayer	The found sinner becomes an offering Church that trusts, seeks, praises, and remembers the afflicted.
Secret	<i>Respice, Domine, munera supplicantis Ecclesiae ... et saluti credentium perpetua sanctificatione sumenda concede</i>	The Church's gifts and sanctification	The God whose merciful gaze seeks the lost is asked to look upon the Church's gifts and grant that continual sanctification make them serve the salvation of the faithful.
Communion	<i>Gaudium est Angelis Dei</i> (Luke 15:10)	Joy over repentance	The antiphon celebrates repentant restoration; Eucharistic joy does not erase the call to conversion or proper reception.
Postcommunion	<i>Sancta tua nos, Domine, sumpta vivificent</i>	Vivification and lasting mercy	The holy things received give life and prepare the purified faithful for everlasting mercy.
Sense	Synthesis		
Literal	Jesus receives publicans and sinners and answers the Pharisees' and scribes' murmuring with a shepherd and a woman who seek until they find; Peter commands humility, the casting of care on God, vigilance, and resistance in faith.		
Allegorical	Gregory reads the Shepherd as Christ bearing fallen humanity, and the woman and lamp as divine Wisdom manifested in the flesh to restore the Creator's likeness in man. The Church proclaims and sacramentally serves this saving work.		
Moral	Grace takes the initiative, yet the hearer is summoned to repent, humble himself, cast his cares on God, resist the devil, and exchange contempt at another's return for shared joy.		
Anagogical	The angels' joy and the Postcommunion's everlasting mercy direct present repentance toward the restored heavenly communion of angels and redeemed humanity.		

Mercy, Search, and the Re-educated Gaze

Governing question

This formulary does more than describe a sinner's change of condition. It changes the worshipper's way of seeing. The afflicted ask to come under God's merciful gaze; the devil watches for prey; the Shepherd and the woman search; the murmurers look down; the angels behold repentance with joy. The Sunday asks: *whose sight will teach the Church to see?*

Gaze	Object	Action	Liturgical consequence
God's merciful gaze	The solitary, poor, afflicted sinner	<i>Respice in me</i> : look upon me and have mercy	Sin and need are disclosed to mercy instead of hidden by self-sufficiency.
The adversary's appetite	The anxious and isolated Christian	He prowls and seeks someone to devour (1 Pet. 5:8)	Humility includes sobriety, resistance, and solidarity; surrender of care is not passivity.
The seeker's attention	Sheep outside; coin hidden within	Christ searches until he finds; Wisdom lights and sweeps	Grace precedes recovery and reaches both estrangement and obscured likeness.
The murmurer's comparison	Christ receiving sinners	Distance is converted into disdain	Another's restoration appears to threaten one's own claim to righteousness.
The angels' contemplation	One sinner repenting	Heaven's attention becomes shared delight	The Communion schools the earthly assembly in heaven's response to recovered life.

Editorial liturgical synthesis. Luke supplies the searchers, murmurers, and angelic joy; 1 Peter supplies the prowling adversary; the Introit and Secret repeat the petition *Respice*. Their arrangement as one drama of sight is this guide's reading of the appointed formulary, not a claim about a Father's account of its composition.

The governing reversal

The worshipper begins by asking God to look upon him and ends by learning to look with the angels. Between those moments, divine mercy exposes the predator's gaze and judges the false justice that cannot rejoice.

The Gospel's Controversy: Mercy and False Justice

Luke first names the conflict: publicans and sinners draw near to hear Jesus, while Pharisees and scribes murmur because he receives and eats with them. The parables answer an accusation about Christ's table-fellowship. They therefore reveal both the seeker's character and the hearer's possible resistance.

Witness	Direct locus	Exegetical emphasis	Boundary to retain
St. Cyril of Alexandria	<i>Commentary on Luke</i> , Homily 106, on Luke 15:1–10	Christ receives those who approach because he is the saving physician. The accusers make mercy itself an accusation; Christ answers by requiring them to share the joy caused by repentance.	Cyril does not turn welcome into approval of sin. The movement is approach, healing, repentance, and joy.

Witness	Direct locus	Exegetical emphasis	Boundary to retain
St. Gregory the Great	<i>Forty Gospel Homilies</i> , Homily 34	True justice pities; false justice disdains. Converted sinners may love with unusual ardor because memory of their wandering intensifies gratitude.	Gregory expressly avoids making every penitent superior to every person who remained just. His contrast diagnoses dispositions, not a mechanical ranking.
Tertullian	<i>On Patience</i> , 12, receiving Luke 15	Divine patience goes after one sheep and bears it; impatience would have despised the one for the sake of the many. Patience is active pursuit, not mere delay.	This is an early ascetical reception of the parable, not commentary on the Alleluia or on this Roman formulary.

St. Cyril — the physician at the contested table

Homily 106 treats the sinners' willingness to hear as the opening received by the Savior's gentleness. Christ's condescension has a medicinal end: he does not become a participant in their disorder but makes his presence a means of rescue. The murmurers fail because they protect a reputation for exactness against the restoration the Law's Lord desires.

St. Gregory — compassion as the test of justice

Gregory's concise antithesis—true justice has compassion, false justice has disdain—does not suspend judgment. It identifies the just, strong, and patient Judge of the Alleluia as the source of mercy and exposes comparison without charity as counterfeit righteousness.

Mercy has a definite shape

The Gospel does not oppose justice to indifference. The Shepherd finds; the sinner repents; heaven rejoices. Mercy's initiative makes conversion possible, and conversion discloses rather than purchases mercy. The Pharisaic error is not zeal for holiness as such, but refusal of the holy joy proper to a sinner's restoration.

The Shepherd, the Shoulders, and the Home

The first parable is deliberately disproportionate: one is missing, and the seeker refuses to treat that loss as negligible. Patristic interpretation enlarges the one without erasing Luke's direct appeal to each sinner.

Patristic movement	Textual ground	Theological contribution
One sheep as fallen humanity	Gregory, Homily 34, reads the hundred as the fullness of rational creation, the ninety-nine as the angelic hosts remaining above, and the one as humanity wandering through sin.	The Shepherd's descent is not a minor adjustment to an otherwise complete world. In the one human nature, the whole race is sought.
The shoulders as assumed nature and Cross	Gregory connects the carrying to Christ's assumption of human nature and bearing of sin; Ambrose, <i>Exposition of Luke</i> VII.208-210, makes the shoulders the arms of the Cross.	Recovery rests on Christ's labor. The sheep does not climb back by autonomous strength; the Incarnate and Crucified bears it home.
One body in Adam and Christ	Ambrose can speak of the single sheep corporately: humanity was lost in Adam and is gathered in Christ.	Personal repentance belongs inside a common human wound and a common ecclesial restoration. Individual concern and corporate salvation are not rivals.

Patristic movement	Textual ground	Theological contribution
Friends and neighbors	Gregory identifies the rejoicing circle with the angelic hosts; Ambrose likewise places restored humanity amid heavenly joy.	The Communion antiphon is not decorative sentiment. Eucharistic assembly rehearses the communion into which the sinner is carried.

St. Ambrose — one saving work, three parables

In VII.207–212 Ambrose reads the lost sheep, coin, and son as a threefold remedy. He associates the Father, Christ, and the Church with receiving, carrying, and searching, while preserving the unity of the divine work. His shoulder imagery identifies the Cross as the form of the Shepherd’s burden-bearing love.

How to handle the numbers

The Fathers’ hundred and ninety-nine are theological figures of fullness and angelic communion, not a census of saved and lost persons. Nor does one sinner make salvation private: Luke’s singular protects the irreducible value of the person, while Gregory and Ambrose show the one human nature borne home in Christ.

The Drachma: Three Searches Within the House

The second parable repeats the sequence—loss, initiative, finding, convoked joy—but changes the field. The coin is not roaming outside; it is hidden within a house and bears an image whose value remains even when obscured. Gregory, Ambrose, and Gregory of Nyssa use those features differently.

Witness	Woman and lamp	Coin and house	Distinctive result
St. Gregory the Great, Homily 34	The woman signifies divine Wisdom; the lamp is the manifestation of divinity in the earthen vessel of Christ’s flesh. Sweeping names the searching disturbance by which conscience is exposed.	Fallen humanity lies hidden in the house of the world, bearing the Creator’s stamp but obscured by sin.	Incarnation illuminates; searching grace makes the hidden image visible and restores it to heavenly fellowship.
St. Ambrose, <i>Luke</i> VII.211–212	The woman can signify the Church actively searching with the lamp.	The drachma bears the sovereign’s image and belongs to the Church’s treasure. Human dignity is received, not self-minted.	Ecclesial proclamation seeks what belongs to the King and summons the recovered person toward the Father.
St. Gregory of Nyssa, <i>On Virginity</i>, 12	The lamp becomes reason illumined for an inward search; the house is the person’s interior life.	The royal image has been covered by the accumulated dirt of disordered life, not annihilated.	The soul searches its faculties, uncovers the image, and calls the ordered powers of the soul to rejoice.

Source status. Gregory and Ambrose expound Luke 15 directly. Gregory of Nyssa reuses the parable in an ascetical account of self-knowledge. The three readings are compatible levels of reception, but they should not be collapsed: divine Wisdom, the Church, and the searching soul are not interchangeable subjects in the Fathers’ arguments.

Outside and inside

The sheep prevents repentance from becoming mere introspection: the Shepherd comes from beyond the wanderer’s resources. The drachma prevents lost from meaning worthless: the King’s likeness remains the ground of the search. Together they describe rescue as pursuit, illumination, cleansing, and restored communion.

Repentance and the Enlargement of Joy

Movement	Patristic precision	Liturgical placement
Mourning becomes changed life	Gregory defines repentance by joining grief over evil already done to refusal to repeat what must be grieved.	Luke's explicit sinner doing penance governs the Communion's joy; reception cannot be detached from conversion.
Memory becomes ardor	Gregory notes that some converts love more intensely because they remember the danger from which they were rescued.	The Offertory's trust and praise are the found person's gratitude, not a boast over those who did not visibly wander.
Private recovery becomes common feast	Augustine, <i>Confessions</i> VIII.3–4, applies Luke 15 to Victorinus's conversion and asks why the whole Church rejoiced so publicly. A widely known return naturally enlarges the circle that receives the news.	Greater publicity explains the breadth of communal joy; it does not make a prominent convert more valuable before God than an obscure one.
Angelic joy corrects human comparison	Cyril and Gregory require the hearer to rejoice at the good accomplished in another.	The Communion makes the assembly sing the answer the murmurers withheld.

St. Augustine — Victorinus inside Luke's feast

Augustine does not cite the parables as ornament. In *Confessions* VIII he uses their logic to interpret the Church's solemn delight when Victorinus professes the faith publicly: one recovered life becomes a good shared by many. Augustine immediately guards the analogy by denying that wealth or fame makes one soul preferable to a poor person's soul.

Grace and response remain braided

The seeker acts first and until the lost is found. Yet Luke names repentance, Peter commands humility and resistance, and the altar asks for sanctification. Patristic praise of prevenient mercy does not make the recovered person inert; moral exhortation does not make the sinner his own shepherd.

The Epistle and Gradual: Entrusted Care, Sober Resistance

First Peter 5:6–11 contains a tightly ordered sequence. Humility places the Christian under God's mighty hand; care is cast upon him because he cares; sobriety recognizes a real adversary; resistance is made in faith and in solidarity with the suffering brotherhood; God himself restores, strengthens, and establishes.

Apostolic act	Its ground	Error excluded	Liturgical echo
Humble yourselves	God's mighty hand will exalt in due time	Humility as self-erasure or despair	The Introit discloses poverty to a God asked to look and pity.
Cast all care upon him	He has care of you	Anxious control or irresponsible passivity	The Gradual sings Psalm 54: <i>Iacta cogitatum tuum in Domino.</i>
Be sober and watch	The devil seeks someone to devour	Naive denial of spiritual danger	The solitary person of the Introit is gathered into a suffering brotherhood.
Resist, steadfast in faith	The same sufferings are borne throughout the brotherhood	Isolated heroism or surrender to fear	The Offertory turns the recovered person toward trust, seeking, praise, and the poor.

Apostolic act	Its ground	Error excluded	Liturgical echo
Endure in hope	The God of all grace will perfect and establish	Treating present affliction as the final word	The Postcommunion asks that holy things give life and prepare for everlasting mercy.

St. Augustine — same-psalm exegesis

In *Exposition on Psalm 54* (the page headed Psalm 55 in modern numbering), 23, Augustine directly explains the Gradual's *Iacta cogitatum tuum*. The burden is not handed to another fragile human being as though that person were the final support; the self and its care are entrusted to the Creator who made and sustains it. Applying that exposition to 1 Peter's adjacent command is a documented scriptural resonance, not Augustine's commentary on the Epistle.

Tertullian — patience is pursuit

On Patience 12 sets the patient Shepherd against the impatience that would despise one lost sheep. This corrects a passive reading of the Alleluia's *patiens*: divine patience seeks, bears, and restores, while Christian patience remains sober and steadfast under the same God.

The predator is not the Sunday's deepest actor

The devil seeks in order to consume; Christ seeks in order to carry home. Vigilance is urgent because danger is real, but hope is rational because the God of all grace has promised the last verbs: restore, strengthen, and establish.

The Secret: Gifts Looked Upon, Believers Sanctified

The complete prayer

Respice, Domine, munera supplicantis Ecclesiae: et saluti credentium perpetua sanctificatione sumenda concede. Per Dominum.

Look, O Lord, upon the gifts of the supplicating Church, and grant that they be received, with perpetual sanctification, for the salvation of believers.

Latin hinge	Grammatical force	Place in the Sunday's movement
<i>Respice, Domine</i>	An imperative asking for God's attentive and favorable regard	The Introit's personal <i>Respice in me</i> reaches the altar as the Church's <i>Respice ... munera</i> . The sought sinner is incorporated into a supplicating offerer.
<i>munera supplicantis Ecclesiae</i>	The gifts of the supplicating Church are the object of the divine gaze	The prayer is ecclesial, not a private transaction; the Church offers while still begging.
<i>saluti credentium</i>	A dative of end or advantage: for the salvation of believers	The gifts' requested fruit is personal and corporate salvation, not visible success or possession.
<i>perpetua sanctificatione</i>	An ablative naming the enduring sanctification with which reception is joined	Sanctification is divine action, not a quality the gifts or offerers manufacture independently.
<i>sumenda concede</i>	The gerundive agrees with <i>munera</i> : grant the gifts to be received	<i>sumenda</i> anticipates the Postcommunion's <i>sumpta</i> : what is petitioned before the canon is confessed after reception.

St. Irenaeus — doctrinal illumination of oblation and reception

Against Heresies IV.18.1–5 teaches that the Church offers from God’s own creation, that acceptance glorifies the offerer rather than supplying a divine need, and that Eucharistic bread receives a heavenly reality. Bodies nourished by it are therefore not destined for annihilation but for resurrection. Irenaeus does not comment on this Secret; he supplies doctrinal control for its movement from ecclesial gifts to sanctification and salvation.

St. Cyril of Jerusalem — sanctified gifts and holy reception

Mystagogical Catechesis 5 (Catechetical Lecture 23), especially 7 and 19–21, describes the invocation of the Holy Spirit upon the gifts, the proclamation of holy things for the holy, and the communicant’s reverent reception. This is direct mystagogical teaching from a different local rite, not evidence for the Roman prayer’s authorship. It illuminates why sanctification and reception belong together without making reception automatic or morally indifferent.

Four verbal threads through the formulary

- *Respice in me* becomes *Respice . . . munera*: the person under mercy enters the offering Church.
- The Collect’s *sperantium* and the Secret’s *credentium* hold hope and faith within God’s protection.
- *perpetua sanctificatione* opens into the Postcommunion’s *Sancta tua*: sanctification is received in holy things, not reduced to an inward idea.
- *sumenda* becomes *sumpta*: petition before reception becomes thanksgiving and a new petition for vivification afterward.

These links are textual observations within the formulary. The patristic witnesses illuminate them; they do not establish a reconstructed history of composition.

Sacramental Completion: Joy, Life, and Everlasting Mercy

The Communion repeats Luke 15:10 rather than choosing an unrelated sacramental verse. The assembly receives while singing heaven’s joy over repentance. The Postcommunion then refuses to let joy remain a momentary emotion: the holy things received are asked to vivify, purify, and prepare the faithful for mercy without end.

Moment	Change of subject	Sacramental consequence
Introit	The isolated sufferer asks God to look upon him.	Need is brought into truthful presence before God.
Gospel	Christ reveals the Shepherd and Wisdom who seek until they find.	Divine initiative judges both despair and contempt.
Offertory	Those who know God’s name trust, seek, praise, and remember the poor.	The recovered person acquires an ecclesial voice and concern for other sufferers.
Secret	The supplicating Church asks God to look upon her gifts.	Personal rescue becomes common oblation ordered to believers’ salvation.
Communion	The Church sings the angels’ joy over one sinner repenting.	The murmurer’s gaze is replaced by a received, heavenly pattern of desire.
Postcommunion	The Church speaks as those who have received holy things.	The gift is asked to give life now and prepare the purified for everlasting mercy.

A compact patristic listening sequence

1. At the Introit, enter Gregory’s contrast between the merciful gaze and disdain: ask to be seen before judging who belongs.

2. In the Epistle and Gradual, entrust the whole burden to God, then remain sober, communal, and steadfast.
3. At the Alleluia, hear Tertullian's active patience: the just Judge seeks rather than dismisses the one.
4. In the Gospel, distinguish Cyril's physician, Gregory's Shepherd, Ambrose's Cross, and the several patristic searches for the coin.
5. At the Offertory and Secret, let the found person become part of the supplicating Church; notice *Respice, sanctificatione*, and *sumenda*.
6. At Communion, refuse the murmurers' response and receive the angels' joy as a demand for repentance and charity.
7. After Communion, ask that what has been *sumpta* give life and prepare the whole person for everlasting mercy.

Guardrails for the whole reading

- Mercy is not indifference: Luke's joy is joy over repentance, under the just and patient Judge.
- Grace is not passivity: the seeker initiates, while the found person repents, resists, offers, and receives.
- Vigilance is not despair: the predator is real, but Christ seeks to save and the God of grace promises to establish.
- Patristic number symbolism is not demographic arithmetic: the ninety-nine and the one articulate fullness, fall, and restoration.
- The image is obscured, not self-restoring: dignity grounds the search, while incarnation, Cross, illumination, and cleansing accomplish recovery.
- Eucharistic sanctification is not automatic fruitful reception: the prayer remains supplication and orders the gifts to the salvation of believers.

Primary References

- *Missale Romanum* (1962), *Dominica Tertia post Pentecosten*; printed propers and English rendering. The full Secret is also indexed in the Corpus Orationum record.
- Holy Scripture: 1 Peter 5:6–11; Luke 15:1–10; Psalms 24, 54, 7, 9, and the Communion verse Luke 15:10.
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- St. Gregory the Great, *Forty Gospel Homilies*, Homily 34, published English translation and locus.
- Tertullian, *On Patience*, 12, working public-domain text.
- St. Ambrose, *Exposition of the Gospel of Luke* VII.207–212, Latin text.
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- St. Augustine, *Confessions* VIII.3–4, Victorinus and the Church's joy; *Exposition on Psalm 54*, 23, on the Gradual verse, page headed Psalm 55.
- St. Irenaeus, *Against Heresies* IV.18.1–5, oblation, Eucharist, and resurrection.
- St. Cyril of Jerusalem, *Mystagogical Catechesis* 5 (Catechetical Lecture 23), 7 and 19–21, sanctification and reception.